the weak leadership of Manmohan Singh in his second term, and divergence over the strategy of the pivot resulted in a drawdown in the Indo–US relationship.

To counter an increasingly assertive China and perceptions of United States decline, Washington announced a strategic pivot toward Asia in late 2011.[25] Soon after, in January 2012, this strategy was rechristened as “strategic rebalancing” by the Pentagon. Pivot or “strategic rebalancing” indicates America’s desire to balance China’s growing economic and military influence in Asia. The pivot emphasises strengthening America’s existing alliances as well as building partnerships with like-minded states in the region. India has emerged as an important element in the US pivot. Aimed at balancing China’s growing power, New Delhi is a natural strategic choice for Washington: the only state in Asia comparable to China in geography and demography, an economic growth story of the 21st century, and a state which believes in democratic and liberal values.[26]

From the very initiation of the rebalancing strategy in December 2011, the Obama administration underscored India’s important role in the new US framework for Asia. In fact, Leon E. Panetta, former Secretary of Defense, during his visit to New Delhi in June 2012, called the India–US defence partnership a lynchpin of America’s rebalancing strategy. He asked New Delhi to play a bigger role in the security of the Asia-Pacific region.[27] For Washington, India is an important strategic choice. For India, too, China’s growing military and economic prowess poses a strategic challenge.[28] Balancing China’s increasing economic and military power has been a strategic priority given serious differences between New Delhi and Beijing. The Sino–Indian border dispute continues to fester. The China–Pakistan “axis” has only grown stronger in recent years. India remains wary of China’s intentions in the Indian Ocean